whenever we did this because she hated getting into choppers. If anything, it was always my endeavour to keep things simple. At Mhow, for example, all three Commandants would come to the helipad to receive me. I discontinued that practice straightaway. Not only should no one come to the helipad, except the Liaison Officer, but there should be no presentation of bouquets and such. It took some time, but when the point was driven home again and again, the changes began to take effect. Fortunately, Rawat was of the same view and these were some of the thoughts we had batted around in Dimapur, so I knew he would back me up.

By now, I had attended hundreds of war games either as a student or in the formations or even conducted them myself. If there was a common thread running through them all, and I had experienced it first-hand, it was that Blue Land (India) always won. We even had software to predict the outcome of engagements, but these results, if not favouring Blue Land, were invariably overturned by the Control. This was the most serious in the HC course, where the war game is on 'actuals'. The students would be drawing the wrong lessons and even worse, on termination of the course, go to their new assignments and make the same mistakes. Only this time, the enemy would be real. At HQ ARTRAC, we coined the quote, 'It is better to lose on the sand model, than on the field of battle', and asked that it should be put up in all the sand-model rooms where the war games are played.

My father and mother, and Veena's mother, were to join us for the summer months. Isha and Simon were to come too, as soon as the term break commenced. The Western Command War Game was scheduled for the middle of the month and we had planned it in such a manner that our parents would come from Pune to Chandigarh by air on the last day of the WG, and

Copyright © Penguin Random House India Not for circulation